Skipper. But Rahul Gandhi was more direct, and asked me to call him ‘Rahul’, after momentarily hesitating.

We talked and talked about cabals and kings for close to four hours until I apologized for delaying his lunch. In the end he said, ‘You said nothing. You revealed nothing.’ Maybe it was my training, but it was not deliberate. The only question I found difficult to answer and regretted then and now was when he asked, ‘Will you walk with us in Kashmir?’ But we did talk about Kashmir, and we discussed many things that are best kept private. But there is one thing I told him that merits wider dissemination, because it is equally relevant throughout India. I told him that the Yatra in the Valley would be the icing on the cake, because people feel that the Gandhis are not easily accessible and don’t find the time for ordinary citizens. I clarified lest he feel bad that my personal experience had been totally the opposite, and he was gracious with his time and always at ease. But that perception had built up over time and because of propaganda, which his Yatra needed to correct.

And he did correct it magnificently. Rahu’s visit to Kashmir revived the ‘Idea of India’. The Yatra truly became the ultimate symbol of Bharat Jodo and national integration in Kashmir. Farooq travelled to Lakhanpur to welcome the Yatra to the Jammu–Kashmir border. Omar Abdullah, Mehbooba Mufti, M.Y. Tariqami and Muzaffar Shah, among others, joined the Yatra, braving the freezing temperatures and biting cold. The turnout in Qazigund arranged by Gulam Ahmed Mir, the former state Congress chief, was incredible. But most of all, ordinary Kashmiris turned out in huge numbers to join Rahul Gandhi as the Yatra entered the Valley.

His entry into the Valley with the Tricolour was a remarkable display of patriotism and unity. It needs to be said that given the turbulent and fraught situation in Jammu and Kashmir, it is not easy to mobilize more than 5,000 to 8,000 people. To then be met with 20,000 to 25,000 people is unimaginable. This continued when the whole state, from the Valley, from Jammu, from Ladakh and elsewhere, joined Rahul, Priyanka and many Opposition leaders at the Sher-e-Kashmir cricket stadium amid heavy snowfall (again, a first). Rahul’s powerful speech at the Sher-e-Kashmir